

Bystander Response to Rape: Can A Victim Attract Help?¹

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The present study was designed to suggest sounds a woman might make that may attract the greatest amount of help. In the context of a simulated rape, the sounds that were tested were (1) a woman screaming "Help, rape, call the police"; (2) a woman screaming "fire"; (3) the sound of a whistle; and (4) a control consisting of the sounds of the struggle without one of the above messages. We concluded that when the situation provides little information bystanders help more frequently to "Help, rape" . . . than to the "Fire" message. Under conditions of high information, Fire is the least successful message in attracting indirect help and we concluded that Fire is not statistically superior at attracting direct help. For logistical and other reasons, we feel that the "Help Rape" message is superior to the whistle sound. In addition, we found only a few people who would try to help directly by putting themselves at physical risk. These individuals were male, and felt assured that they could handle the physical conflict as a result of prior training (physical defense, varsity athletics, etc.). We concluded that direct help is

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not probable when environmental or sociological factors lead bystanders to expect a physical confrontation with the perpetrator of the attack as a cost of interfering. Thus we feel that further research should focus efforts at causing bystanders to contact the police, as recent evidence demonstrates that the police respond to "crime in progress" calls within 3 minutes in at least two major cities.

Primarily through the efforts of feminists, the crime of rape has become a topic of national concern over the last 10 years (c.f. Brownmiller, 1975; Griffin, 1971; Medea & Thompson, 1974). The concern is very much warranted as the available evidence indicates that the impact of rape can be quite traumatic. Burgess and Holmstrom (1974) interviewed 92 victims of rape or attempted rape in the Boston area and found that this experience caused all women "disorganization in their life-style." For example, approximately half changed their residence within a "short" period of time after the rape and a large number changed their telephone numbers. Often the victims lived in fear that the rapist knew her whereabouts and would return for her. Nightmares and phobias related to the environment in which the rape had occurred were not uncommon. Acute reactions following a rape or attempted rape endure, on the average, for 2 to 3 weeks after the attack.

While bystander intervention research is approximately 12 years old, and assumedly was begun, in part, as a result of the Kitty Genovese incident, there have been only 2 published articles exploring bystanders response to a man attacking a woman. Borofsky, Stollak, and Messe (1971) found that bystanders are less likely to intervene in an attack by a man on a woman in comparison to other fights between different gender combinations. Shotland and Straw (1976) found, in a series of studies, that bystanders are less likely to intervene when a man attacks a woman if the couple is married rather than strangers. Bystanders intervene less frequently in the former instance because they are more likely to believe that a husband will remain and fight whereas a stranger will turn and run. Bystanders are also more likely to see more harm being done by a stranger rather than a woman's husband. In addition, given no information about the relationship between a man and a woman in a physical fight, bystanders are most likely to attribute a relationship between the man and woman and are thus less likely to intervene. However, neither Shotland and Straw, nor Borofsky et al. addressed the applied question of finding a workable strategy that a woman who is being attacked can use to obtain help from bystanders. This is the purpose of the current inquiry. It is a particularly salient question as various individuals, through the popular media and other sources, have made a number of different and often conflicting suggestions concerning the course of action a woman should take if she is being attacked.

For example, *Human Behavior* magazine (Anonymous, 1978) quotes psychiatrist Gene Abel as suggesting that a woman "should confront the rapist verbally,

using all the assertiveness she can muster . . . ,” while Storaska (1975) suggests that at the beginning of an attack the victim should do nothing of an antagonistic or violent nature. In terms of screaming, Abel is quoted as suggesting that women should scream “Fire.” Medea and Thompson suggest that the victim shout, “Help, call the police, rape.” A pamphlet entitled *What every woman should know about self protection* (1978) suggests screaming or the use of whistles or buzzers.

Evidence does exist indicating that a “victim” has some control over whether help is provided or not. Shotland and Johnson (1978) found that nonverbal cues (eye contact and body orientation) determined the degree of help obtained by a male who twisted his ankle and fell. Langer and Abelson (1972) found, in a nonemergency situation, that some semantic constructions of asking a favor obtained more help for a solicitor than other semantic constructions. Shotland and Straw found that if a woman yelled “Get away from me, I don’t know you,” she obtained more help than if she yelled “get away from me, I don’t know why I ever married you.” Hence, what a woman who is being attacked might say or do may be important in determining whether she receives help or not.

Is an attempt to attract help and drive off a rapist likely to scare him away? In general, it appears that self-protective measures consisting of kicking, hitting, screaming or yelling for help and running, do raise the probability of thwarting the attempted rape. Walker and Brodsky (1976) reported a study of rape in the Denver area conducted by Giacinti and Tjaden (1973). They reported that approximately 35% of 915 rape attempts studied were not completed. Two-thirds of these were prevented as a result of the victim’s “active resistance.” This active successful resistance consisted of running away (24%), fighting off the attack (18.4%), crying aloud (15%), and verbally refusing (10.5%). The remaining events consisted of another person coming to the aid of the victim (10.5%), the police arriving (6.3%), and “other interruptions” (14.5%). Hindelang and Davis (1977), in an analysis of LEAA Crime Panel data collected in 1972 across 13 different cities, found that in unsuccessful rape attempts approximately 80% of the women took self-protective actions while those women who were raped successfully actively tried to protect themselves approximately 50% of the time. The percentage of women who screamed was similar for both successful and unsuccessful rapes, yielding no evidence of the efficacy of screaming and or yelling for help by themselves in scaring the rapist away.

What are the physical consequences of rape, successful or not? Data indicate the *average* victim of rape or attempted rape does not appear to suffer *severe physical injury*. Hindelang and Davis reported that approximately 50% of the victims of completed rapes and “one-eighth” of those who reported attempted rapes were injured to the extent that some “medical attention” was required.

However, the modal amount of medical attention required was minimal. Of those women who required medical attention, approximately 60% received emergency treatment while only approximately 10% had to be hospitalized overnight or longer. Hence there is the probability of physical injury; however, current evidence indicates that the *average* injury does not reach calamitous proportions.³

The purpose of the present study is to determine whether some of the audible signals to obtain help that have been suggested women try when being attacked are more efficacious in obtaining help than others. The messages to be examined are: (1) "Help, rape, call the police"; (2) "Fire"; and (3) The sound of a whistle used by police, referees at sporting events, etc. These messages should create differential helping rates by either clarifying or confusing the situation for bystanders. The messages should produce maximally different response rates when bystanders are confronted with a situation that is ambiguous and difficult to define. The information that the message adds to such a situation should then either help clarify or further confuse the bystanders. Likewise, if a situation is crystal clear and well defined, the message should have little effect on the further clarification of the situation and hence little impact on raising helping rates, although a confusing message may lower them.

The hypothesis to be tested is that "Help, rape, call the police," as a result of its clear message, will attract help from the greatest number of bystanders. This hypothesized effect should be strongest when the situation itself provides the least amount of information. On the other hand, if a woman should shout "fire" while a man is attempting to rape her, one might expect that this message may confuse any bystander who happened to be listening and thus cause a lower level of help because of the inconsistency between the incident and the message. Again, the confusion should be greatest when the situation provides a low level of information.

³This statement is made based upon the length of a hospital stay. It is conceivable that a rape victim may suffer cuts that would require stitches to close and not result in a long hospital stay. Nevertheless, the victim may find the injury quite calamitous. In addition, while survey research provides estimates on the degree of physical injury as a result of sexual assault, surveys do not provide information on the probability of rape ending in homicide. There appears to be no hard data of this kind; however, experts estimate the number of rapes that end in murder to be quite small. Harry T. O'Reilly, a former New York city police sex crime investigator and currently the Director of the Institute for the Study of Investigative Services at John Jay College of Criminal Justice, states (Note 2) that "crime related homicides are very small in any given year in New York city—perhaps 10–15 of the 15–1600 homicides reported each year are sex crime related, and of the approximately 4000 rapes reported each year, perhaps 10–15 result in homicide (remember the unknown unreported quotient)."

We also hypothesize that males will be more likely to help than females only if we make the sex comparison with the segment of the sample that chooses a helping action that places themselves at physical risk. We make this hypothesis, as Huston, Conner, Ruggiero, and Geis (Note 1) had found that males were overwhelmingly represented in a population of people who were injured while intervening into criminal acts.

METHOD

While Shotland and Straw (Experiment 1) used live actors to present the "fight" stimuli to their subjects, we decided against this procedure since we planned to present the rape to subjects primarily as an incident they happened to overhear. As the dialogue was extensive, a live presentation would have been very difficult to standardize.

The incident staged by Shotland and Straw could be portrayed effectively, as a fight can believably start in front of others, and can certainly occur in open public areas. One imagines that fights grow out of passions and are rarely planned, while it is difficult to conceive of a rape between strangers that is not at least to some degree premeditated. Thus one does not expect to view a rape in progress, with the exception of an abduction of a woman at the start of a rape. If one happened upon a rape scene in a public area, we feared it would be implausible. One might consider oneself unlucky to overhear a rape, but it would be reasonably plausible to do so. Hence, we decided to present the stimuli primarily through the auditory mode. To standardize the dialogue with its varied inflections, we needed to tape it. However, tape recordings generally do not pass for live voices. Thus, we needed a sound system which would eliminate the auditory cues that are used by people to distinguish between taped and live voices.

Apparatus

First, we needed to keep the distortion produced by the reproduction of the sound at a minimum. A Technic SU 7300 40 Watt integrated amplifier, which is rated at less than 0.08% total harmonic distortion at full power, was utilized. The tape deck was a ¼" reel to reel Pioneer model 1011L with a Dolby noise reduction system, which was utilized to reduce tape hiss. The Dolby system was augmented with another noise reduction system, the JVC ANRS NR 1020. The speaker consisted of four Phillips AD 5061 MS Metra 5", 8 OHM loudspeakers clustered as tightly as possible and mounted on a 14.5 x 11.5 x .5 inch thick piece of plywood. Blocks of white pine 4.0 x 3.25 x .75 inches were glued to the four corners and were braced in pairs by white pine measuring 9.75 x 3.19 x .75 inches. The speakers were designed to produce the acoustical range

of human voice, and four loud speakers were used in parallel series to damp fundamental cone resonance. The speakers were clustered as closely as possible in an attempt to provide a focal point for the sound. The speaker was braced to reduce a "boomie" sound produced by the vibration of the board to which the loudspeakers were mounted. In addition, a 200 HZ filter was used to further eliminate the sound of the vibration.

The recording was made in a sound studio which provided directional microphones as well as an acoustically dead environment. This was necessary in order to eliminate "precedence effects" resulting from echoes (c.f. Whitfield, 1967, p. 186-189) which would produce further distortion.⁴

Subjects

Subjects were 87 male and female students who participated in order to receive extra course credit for either an introductory psychology or an educational psychology course, during the summer and fall of 1978, at The Pennsylvania State University.

Procedure

Subjects were recruited ostensibly to take part in an eye-hand coordination task. When subject arrived at the fifth floor experimental room, he or she was met by a male experimenter who was approximately 5'8" and 140 pounds. Subjects were asked to fill out a questionnaire inquiring about height, weight, GPA, SAT scores, etc. and then were instructed how to perform the pursuit rotor task. Subjects performed the pursuit rotor task at three different speeds for 2-minute periods at each speed. They were then told that the study was designed to determine the relationship between eye-hand coordination and other factors, such as intellectual ability. Subjects were asked if they had any questions. The experimenter answered any questions that were asked and then began to search through his desk drawers, obviously looking for something. The experimenter then apologized and explained to subject that he had run out of the extra credit card that students are to pass on to their instructor. The experimenter mentioned that he had to wait for the next subject but that a professor who was downstairs on the fourth floor, in Room 402, could give the student an extra credit card. Subject gathered his or her belongings and was given directions to go down one flight of steps and how to find Room 402.

⁴The sound system was played in 9'9" x 14'7" room with hard walls and floor and an acoustically tiled ceiling and a closed 2" thick wood and glass door. The sound spilled through the door into a 133' x 6' corridor with a hard floor and walls and an acoustically tiled ceiling which produced a slight echo.

On the door of Room 402, subject found a note which read: "Chuck, I have an upset stomach—I've gone to the bathroom, I'll be back in a few minutes—Please *Wait*"; The message was signed Lance. Subjects would characteristically wait outside of Room 402, reading one of two bulletin boards.

After approximately 2 minutes, if the subject was randomly assigned to one of the high information conditions (visual and auditory presentation), he or she would have heard a loud bang as the actor's leg hit a metal door at the end of a darkened hallway approximately 95 feet from Room 402. The metal door was opened, a 5'8", 150-pound male pulled a 5'2", 115-pound female through the door. Struggling with the woman, the rapist then pushed open a door to a room on his right and shoved the woman inside and locked the door. This brief visual scene (there was no dialogue), which was in a direct line of sight for the subject, lasted for approximately 3 seconds. After the door was locked, the tape started playing. If subject was randomly assigned to one of the low information conditions (auditory information only), the situation started for the subject when he or she first heard the sound of the tape coming from inside the room.

To create the tape, we employed graduate students from the drama department who were recommended by a faculty member from that department for both their acting ability and ability to improvise. We also consulted with a woman who had been raped concerning the believability of the dialogue. The scene starts with the rapist seating the woman in a chair and attempting to remove the woman's clothing while she is protesting and trying to hold her clothing in order to prevent its removal. Both the woman and man at first try to stay calm. Their voices indicate tension. The volume of the voices rises and falls as they struggle for physical control and control over their emotions. The dialogue of the scene is given below and indications are made of the locations that the messages—i.e., "Help rape," "Fire," etc.—were inserted on the experimental tapes. The control condition simply had none of the messages inserted into the dialogue. The total length of the dialogue was 1 minute 12 seconds, followed by 53 seconds of the woman's sobbing.

F: Please let go!

M: Sit down over in the chair.

F: Let go.

M: Okay, now listen, I don't want you to make a sound. Listen to me! Listen to me! Don't yell, don't scream, just don't make a fuckin' sound.

F: What are you doing . . .

M: Don't make a sound!

F: Let go of me, please! let . . . , what are you doing? Let . . .

F: (Message)

M: I'll hurt you if I have to, I'll kill you if I have to. Don't make a sound! Do you want to get hurt?

F: No, no, please, I don't want to get hurt. Please.

M: Just shut up. Just shut up!

F: No! No!

M: Put your hands down.

F: No! No!

M: Put your hands down. Okay, now be quiet. Be quiet!

8 second pause

F: Please don't, please don't (whimpering).

M: Don't! Don't!

M: Damn you, put your hands down! (Sounds of female struggling)

M: Put your hands down!

F: Let go of me, goddamn you! Let go of me.

M: Goddamn who? Now shut up! Shut up.

heavy breathing

M: Okay, that's all I want.

F: Please, please don't!

M: Just for you to shut up. Do you read me?

F: Yes.

M: Now shut up! (heavy breathing)

M: Put your hands down.

F: (screaming) I can't!

M: Put your hands down.

F: I can't. Please! (starting to cry) No!

M: Shut up! (shouting)

F: (Message)

F: (muffled crying) No (crying).

M: I'll cut you up. Do you want me to kill you?

F: (loud crying) No.

M: Shut up! Shut up! (shouting) Shut up!

F: (loud crying)

M: Stop. Shh! Shh!

F: Stop it! (more crying)

M: Shh! Shh! (female crying in background)

54 seconds of female sobbing

Subject's behavior was constantly under observation from the moment subject appeared on the fourth floor. The observations were made from behind the stairway fire doors by looking through the partition between the two doors. Viewing in this fashion, it is possible to see the entire hallway without being seen in return. Additional elements of the procedure was the placement of an experimental assistant in each of the five exits of the floor to prevent a participant from leaving without being fully debriefed. In addition, if a participant came barreling down the hall and appeared to be about to put a shoulder

to the door to the room where the simulated rape was taking place, a small woman stepped out from behind the fire doors and explained it was an experiment.

Subjects were interviewed immediately following the experiment and were fully debriefed by the first author, who spent up to 45 minutes with each subject. The interviews were unstructured and were designed to elicit subject's perceptions of the incident. A questionnaire was also administered consisting primarily of questions designed to measure the participant's perception of the staged rape and his or her feelings about participating in the experiment. The questionnaire was similar to the one used by Shotland and Straw consisting of questions that were answered in a multiple choice format, and 4- and 5-point scales.

Ethical Considerations

The experiment appeared to us to be potentially useful and we felt that prior experience indicated that the potential risk of harm to subjects was quite small. The senior author discussed the study with several of his colleagues. A proposal was then sent to the University Ethics Committee who approved it but indicated there might be some risk. The proposal was then sent to the Biomedical Committee to ascertain the probability of physical risk, and their recommendation was then sent to the "Core Ethics Committee" who, after observing a demonstration of various features of the study, approved it. The committee asked that we include as few subjects as possible to minimize the potential of running across a "thin skulled" subject. To gain statistical power, hypotheses were carefully stated, and hence one-tail tests were employed where appropriate.

Campus police were also told of the project and they indicated it would not interfere with their, or the fire department's, functions and pledged their cooperation.

RESULTS

Subjects found the staged incident to be believable; i.e., 94% indicated they were totally unaware of being in a study involving a simulated rape. In fact, at the beginning of the interview-debriefing, a large proportion of subjects tried to explain to the interviewer that they were just there for an extra credit card and had already participated in a study on eye-hand coordination. Of the five subjects discarded because they were suspicious, three had prior knowledge of bystander research through course work and had guessed that this might be what was occurring. Two additional subjects were removed from the analyses of the effectiveness of the message as they responded so quickly that they did not have a chance to hear the message (a male who intervened

and a woman who took self-protective precautions). Thus 80 subjects could be analyzed by experimental condition. These subjects were equally distributed across the cells of the design and were equally apportioned in each cell by sex.

There was greater variance in subjects' behavior to the simulated rape than has been reported in most previous helping behavior studies. People who did not help were relatively easy to classify. However, we needed three distinct categories to adequately classify individuals who responded in a manner that could be construed as helping. The first category consisted of direct helpers, i.e., nine people who tried to deal with the situation themselves by personally attempting to interfere in the simulated rape. The second group of helpers were indirect helpers. These 23 individuals sought help from others, usually the upstairs experimenter, in order to provide help. Indirect helpers were then willing to go back downstairs in the company of another individual and help. The last category consisted of three males we termed passive helpers. They were individuals who remained on the floor during the attack and did not try to assist until another person approached them after the stimulus had ended (an experimental assistant coming to get the subject). They would then report the incident, appearing both concerned and ready to help. As this last type of helping attempt would only be successful through the chance appearance of a second bystander, these subjects were considered nonhelpers for the purposes of the analysis.^{5,6}

As one would predict from Shotland and Straw, there was no difference in the overall helping rate between the entire sample of men (43%) and the entire sample of women (36%), $\chi^2(1) = .48$, *ns*, nor were there any interactions that produced any effects on the *overall* helping rate that involved subject's sex.

Table 1 illustrates the percentage of participants who responded by helping collapsed across sex. As Table 1 portrays, a woman is more likely to obtain help if she can be seen for approximately 3 seconds during the beginning of the attack and is vocally protesting (68%) than if she is out of bystanders sight and is only protesting and pleading verbally (13%), $\chi^2(1) = 26.99$, $p < .001$.

The messages had no overall effects on the rate of intervention. Even in the actor absent condition, the overall helping rates were not strikingly different as a function of the message. However, as Table 1 indicates, there does appear to be a weak trend indicating that in the actor absent condition the "Help, rape" message may be more useful in attracting help than is the "Fire" message (Fisher exact $p = .10$). Additional support for this result can be found by looking at our pilot data.

⁵Two of these subjects occurred in the "whistle" condition, one with actors present and one without actors. The third subject occurred in the actor present control condition.

⁶It should be noted that the rates for direct intervention, indirect intervention, and no help are not "independent" dependent variables.

TABLE 1

PERCENTAGE OF INTERVENERS BY MESSAGE AND THE VISUAL
PRESENCE OR ABSENCE OF ACTORS

	Help, Rape, Police	Fire	Whistle	Control
Actor present	60 <i>n</i> = 10	60 <i>n</i> = 10	70 <i>n</i> = 10	80 <i>n</i> = 10
Actor absent	30 <i>n</i> = 10	0 <i>n</i> = 10	10 <i>n</i> = 10	10 <i>n</i> = 10

We collapsed the data from several different trial variations of the actor absent conditions, which, for the most part, made use of a different dialogue, different voices, and was staged in a restroom. After removing seven participants due to questions concerning whether subject believed the situation, we find that 50% ($N = 16$) of the participants intervened when they heard "Help, rape, call the police" in comparison to a 22% ($N = 18$) intervention rate for the "Fire" message, $\chi^2(1) = 2.86$, $p < .10$, with the intervention rate produced by the whistle sound (36%, $N = 14$) falling in between the "Help, rape" and "Fire" messages. This order of helping by message condition is the same order found in the main study.

Using Eddington's (1972) procedure for determining an overall alpha level for the results of several different investigations, an overall probability of $p = .02$ is obtained, indicating that the "Help, rape" message attracts more help than the "Fire" message under conditions of low information.

Interestingly, nonintervening bystanders occasionally reported some confusion concerning the "Fire" message and the whistle sound. Those who had not heard that a woman should scream "Fire" if she is being attacked reported being confused as to why a woman who is being attacked would yell "Fire." The whistle sound caused some bystanders to question whether there was someone else present or on the way.

Ten of the participants took what appeared to be self-protective measures, including leaving the floor (2), going to an open room and closing the door (3), and flattening themselves against a wall so as to create a small profile (5). Individuals who took self-protective precautions were equally divided between the actor present and actor absent conditions. Of those individuals who took some form of self-protective measures, only the group of individuals who flattened themselves against a wall contained any interveners. Three of five (60%) of this group helped indirectly.

As we had predicted, a greater percentage of men (17%) than women (5%) intervened directly ($Z = 1.77$, $p < .04$). However, the strategies taken by direct

interveners can be further divided into two independent categories. First, some subjects immediately attempted to enter the room where the simulated rape was occurring. Second, others stood well back from the door and attempted to make their presence known to the people inside the room by shouting. The direct interveners, who took the greatest physical risk by trying to enter the room and hence assumedly confront the rapist, were composed entirely of men (Fisher exact $p = .03$). The remaining four individuals who were counted as direct helpers were equally divided between men and women. It should be noted, however, that direct help with high physical risk was used by only 28% of the total number of male *helpers* and that both styles of direct intervention combined were only used by 39% of male *helpers* and 13% of women *helpers*.

Interestingly, there was a trend indicating that direct interveners were more likely to occur in the actor present fire condition, with 50% or half of the 10 subjects intervening in this fashion in comparison to 10% or 1 direct helper in each of the remaining actor present conditions (Fisher exact $p = .13$)⁷. It would also appear that the "Fire" message produced fewer indirect helpers (10%) than did the control condition (70%), the whistle sound (60%) or the "Help, rape" message (50%). Fisher exact probabilities for these differences are, respectively, .02, .05, and .13.

The only time interval for which a meaningful estimate of helping latency could be obtained is the time from the start of the stimulus to the *beginning* of intervention directed behavior. This was so for two reasons. First, if an indirect observer ran upstairs to get help from either the experimenter or a late working faculty member, we could not obtain a reliable estimate of the time to the reporting of the incident. Second, the time to the end of an indirect intervention is uncertain. For example, how long would it take to convince another individual without direct knowledge of the situation that a rape was occurring and that his or her help was required? There were no significant differences in time, either by condition or type of intervention. All interveners began their intervention behavior quickly. The grand mean of elapsed time to the beginning of intervention was 13.45 seconds ($Sd = 13.39$).

Nonhelpers, as participants did in general, first attempted to discern what was occurring. Could it be a film, TV (a number of subjects reported trying to make themselves believe it to be a film or TV), or people fooling around? Frequently, nonhelpers would try to avoid the sound at this stage by leaving the floor, entering the room where the person they were supposed to meet

⁷The actor absent whistle condition produced one direct helper, and one direct helper responded to the actors before a message was presented.

should have been, and closing the door behind them, or walking to a far corner of the floor. In the sound only condition, people would, at first, frequently deny having heard any sound at the beginning of the debriefing and then indicate that they had heard it. A number of other subjects reported being confused over the correct course of action to take. Still others appeared to have decided on directly intervening only not to be able to carry through.

Because the origin of the sound was mentioned as a source of confusion by some subjects, during the interview, we decided to run a live voice sound only control condition to guard against the possibility that the low intervention rate in this condition was an artifact of the taping procedure. The live voice replication resulted in an intervention rate (2/10) which was similar to the one found with tape (1/10). The interviews and debriefing yielded similar results as the tape procedure.

Results from the post-experimental questionnaire indicated that helpers were more likely to perceive the situation as a rape, with 71% describing it as such in comparison to 39% of nonhelpers who saw the situation as a quarrel equally often (37%), $\chi^2(1) = 8.14, p < .001$. Helpers also were more likely to view themselves as aroused, judged by their rating on a 5-point scale, ($M = 4.01$) than did nonhelpers ($M = 3.03$), Behrens Fisher $t'(71) = 4.02, p < .001$. The same result was obtained by using the arousal ratings provided by the observer who coded the participants behavior $t'(70) = 9.84, p < .001$. As Shotland and Straw's data suggested, helpers were much more likely to perceive the woman and attacker as strangers (74%) than were nonhelpers (48%), $\chi^2(1) = 5.33 < .025$. Again, as Shotland and Straw's data would suggest, helpers thought that greater "physical injury" was occurring to the women ($M = 2.79$) than did nonhelpers ($M = 2.44$), $t'(82) = 2.28, p < .05$. In addition, helpers believed that the woman would suffer greater "emotional injury" than ($M = 3.17$) did nonhelpers ($M = 2.79, t'(75) = 2.87, p < .01$).

On the scale concerning the personal impact of the study filled out by participants following the debriefing, 100% of the subjects indicated that they felt the study should be continued. Twelve subjects indicated that they expected to continue thinking about the study for several hours, while three of these subjects also indicated that they may be concerned about it for a long time afterwards. These individuals were followed up. All of these participants, with the exception of one, indicated that following the evening of the experiment they were no longer upset. The one female had indicated she had found the experience disturbing for about 2 weeks. However, she went to great pains to indicate that it was not totally a negative experience—that she was glad to have participated because it was an "interesting experience," a real "learning experience." She indicated that the way it had affected her negatively was that prior to the study she had been "hesitant to walk around at night and that the experience had strengthened that."

DISCUSSION

It would appear that bystanders wanted two confirming sources of information before deciding to help the woman. We have several indications that the "two source" hypothesis is correct. First, only one individual intervened to the sight stimulus (a male direct intervener) before the sound occurred. (We had a participant who attempted to flee as quickly to the first few seconds of sound.) Almost all of our participants in the combined visual and auditory conditions, during the interview, reported that the visual scene was not clearly interpreted. The scene appeared to some subjects as two people "fooling around" and to other subjects as two males. Participants reported that they interpreted the incident definitely as a serious one only after hearing the woman's voice, which assumedly had clarified what they had seen. For example, one male participant, upon seeing the actors, started to laugh; when he heard the woman's voice, his hands went to his hair, a surprised and fearful expression appeared on his face, he turned around and ran upstairs for help. In addition, one explanation for a higher rate of intervention in an "auditory only" pilot study that we conducted in comparison to rates obtained in the present study was that it had the sounds that might accompany a physical conflict, such as overturning chairs, wastebaskets, etc., that could be used as additional confirmatory material. These sounds were not apparent on our primary tapes. This also occurred in the limited "live" voice replication of our primary study. On several occasions, the male accidentally pushed a chair into a filing cabinet and after each such occurrence the subject intervened. In addition, a few non-intervening subjects' in the primary study noted that they would have intervened if in the sound only condition there had been some additional indications that a rape was going on. These subjects specifically mentioned needing to hear the sounds of a physical struggle in order to intervene. Thus, it appears that two sources of information, i.e., "the act" plus the dialogue, gave subjects sufficient information upon which to base a decision to help. The messages could not add sufficient new information to increase the overall helping rate beyond the rates found in the control condition, i.e., the actors plus dialogue with no message. We recognize that the evidence supporting the two information source explanation is not experimental as we do not have the act, dialogue absent condition for comparison. However, a weaker comparison is available and supportive in the phenomenological time series reports of the great majority of subjects in the actor present conditions. These subjects indicated they had misinterpreted the acting sequence until the sound started. The consistency of the information supporting the two information source hypothesis as presented above, appears to us to be compelling.

After people presumably had determined from the stimulus information presented that some form of bystander intervention was required and they

would provide it, they went about solving their problems in two very different ways, i.e., either intervening directly or indirectly. The direct interveners appeared to be very different types of people from their indirect counterparts, and these differences were apparent from their first few words of the interview. During the post-experimental interview, when participants were asked why they did not resort to the other course of action, both groups responded instantly with quite different answers. Indirect interveners responded, in every case, using almost the same expression: "I couldn't do anything myself so I went to get help." Direct interveners responded by stating that there was not enough time to get indirect help (e.g., a police dispatcher said the police would never get there in time), and they would boast that they could "handle the situation" and usually followed that up with a statement that they had some physical defense training. In fact, seven of nine indicated having had instruction in physical defense or boxing. Three of the males were varsity athletes, one was a police dispatcher for a small town police force and was studying to be a policeman, and one was willing to resort to a knife that he carried and took out to use. One of the women had physical defense training but indicated she did not remember it, and then held up her fingers showing the interviewer inch-long fingernails and indicated that she felt they were formidable weapons. These results dovetail nicely with the data of Huston et al. who, in investigating a sample of Californians who were injured while intervening in a criminal situation, found that the sample consisted almost entirely of men who felt they were competent to handle the situation directly.

Shotland and Straw found considerably more direct interveners than did we and only the two direct interveners who responded unusually quickly in their study were similar to our direct interveners in that they expressed great self-assurance. This difference between the results of the two studies appears to be a function of environmental factors. Shotland and Straw's fight occurred in a hall, a situation in which it was possible for the attacker to run away. In this study, the simulated rape occurred in an enclosed room on the fourth floor, a situation in which a bystander cannot expect the rapist to run away without directly confronting the bystander. Results from Shotland and Straw and the present study suggest that direct intervention into a violent situation is not going to occur with great frequency if the bystander expects to be placed in great physical danger by helping. The present study demonstrates that if environmental constraints make it appear that intervention will lead to a physical confrontation bystanders will be less likely to intervene. Also one can conclude from Shotland and Straw that sociological factors, i.e., the belief that a husband would stay and fight an intervening bystander, also lessen the likelihood of direct intervention.

Given physical risk, it is not surprising that only a small percentage of *helpers* (28%) intervened directly. It would seem, then, that it makes sense to attempt

to promote indirect help, i.e., calling the police, for two reasons. First, generalizing from our data, it would seem that only a small percentage of the general population appears to be willing to intervene directly. Second, there is a reasonable probability that in a physical conflict with a criminal, a bystander may not be successful at stopping the crime and may be injured. Indirect interveners, on the other hand, should be more numerous and if they call the police they may be more successful interveners. It would appear that police respond to "crime in progress" calls much more quickly than is commonly believed. Raab (1976) reported that a confidential New York Police Department report indicated that in a typical high crime area the police responded to "crime in progress" calls in under 3 minutes ($M = 2.9$ minutes). Raab also reported a similar figure for the Chicago police.

We had thought that the fact that many of the direct interveners were in the actors present "fire" message condition may be explainable from the results of the interview. A large majority of the participants in the "fire" condition, when asked why a woman would scream fire, responded by stating that she was afraid that if she yelled rape people would run away. Therefore, individuals in the "fire" condition may have seen the "fire" message as a plea for direct action on the part of the victim.

To test this hypothesis, a study was performed where four independent groups, each consisting of 20 males and females, listened to the tapes and rated them on the post-experimental questionnaire to which questions concerning the course of action the victim would like a bystander to take were added. Results indicated that the tapes were not seen as being significantly different from each other on any item, including the attributed desires of the victim for different courses of action to be taken by the bystanders. Thus, we have no confirming evidence that the "fire" condition by itself produced the direct help. Given the striking self-assurance of direct helpers, it does seem reasonable to us that they occurred in the "fire" condition by chance. A second possibility is that the "Fire" message interacts with certain personal characteristics to produce direct intervening behavior; i.e., a certain type of person views the "fire" message as a personal challenge. He or she believes the victim is yelling fire out of fear that bystanders will run the other way, and they wish to demonstrate that they will not behave that way. Chance, however, seems to us the most likely explanation.

We accept the proposition that the "Fire" message is the least viable of the tested messages for attracting help and we cautiously accept that the "Help, rape, call the police" message is the most viable message. The "Fire" message was inferior to at least one other message in all but one situation, that being, as previously mentioned, that marginally more direct helpers were produced in the actor present "fire" condition than in any other actor present condition. However, as mentioned previously, we feel that the most likely explanation

is that this result occurred by chance. In the actor present conditions, the "Fire" message attracted significantly less indirect help than both the control and the whistle and marginally less help than the "Help, rape" message. In addition, under conditions of low information, we cautiously accept the proposition that the "Help, rape" message is a more viable message for attracting help than the "Fire" message. We presented two independent tests of that proposition, that when taken together surpass either the one-tail or two-tail conventional levels of significance.

While empirically we cannot discriminate between the whistle sound and the "Help, rape" message, the "Help, rape" message would appear to be preferable from several points of view. Logistically, one needs no equipment to shout, and there may be no opportunity to reach and use a whistle even if it is carried. It also appears more likely that help would be obtained if a bystander heard only "Help, rape, call the police" than if a bystander heard only a blast on a whistle without any dialogue.

We urge *caution* in the use of the results of this study for three reasons. First, the population was restricted to college students who are at an age when a person may feel most competent to deal physically with the conflict; i.e., the rate of direct intervention particularly may be *lower* in the general population. Second, we interpret the pilot data more cautiously as the methods were somewhat less successful than the method used in the final study. Third, as of this time, there has been no attempt to replicate these studies in other settings with other dialogues. Thus the pilot data is the only evidence we have of the replicability in other settings and situations to demonstrate the external validity of the results.

While we are cautiously accepting the proposition that the "Help, rape" message is superior, this should not be taken as a suggestion that screaming is the first line of defense. In fact, if it is to be used, it probably should be considered the *last* resort. Storaska suggests that a woman should do nothing that will make her situation worse. For example, if a woman is in a situation in which she could not be heard, screaming may only make the situation worse. Certainly, if the rapist has not made any physical move to start the rape, but is attempting to intimidate the woman, attempting to talk him out of it is a strategy with the fewest risks. If a physical struggle is taking place and he has total control, screaming may lead to a successful attempt to smother the screams and may possibly lead to personal harm. This would appear to be the most dangerous situation to scream in. If, on the other hand, the rapist and victim are struggling and he does not have physical control and it does not appear that he is about to obtain it, screaming may be worth the risk as it may both scare him and attract help. If the woman is in a position to run away, shouting may be useful for the same reasons.

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